The Junkie and the Monk

By Mike DeStefano

MIKE: When I was a kid, I had a spark in me. I was happy. I always had a little bit of a flame going, and nothing could really knock it out. I went to Catholic school, but even the nuns couldn't extinguish the flame that dwelled inside me. (They tried.)

INTRODUCTION

On March 6, 2011, former heroin addict and stand-up comedian, Mike DeStefano died of a heart attack. He was 44 years old. Two years before his death, he recorded this heart-felt narrative for The Moth.

And although DeStefano masked his pain with comedy, the people closest knew him as a loving son and a man who healed souls as a drug and HIV/AIDS counselor. After all, it is our trials and tribulations that make us who we are.

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MIKE: At the time of this story, I was twenty-eight years old. I was in the Winn-Dixie supermarket shopping when this weird feeling came over me, and then I fainted, I blacked out. That had happened to me before, but it was on purpose, with drugs. This time it was a little scary. I was in and out of consciousness. I knew something was wrong.

I ended up in the Palm Beach Gardens Medical Center. I had a tube in my nose, and I was in this incredible pain. It turned out I had double-lobal pneumonia. And for a minute I was really concerned about myself. This was weird. I hadn't worried about ***myself*** for a few years, because at home my wife was dying of AIDS, and she was ***really*** sick.

All I could think was, ***I've gotta get out*** **of** ***this hospital. I've gotta get home and take care of her.*** Because all I did was take care of my wife; that was my life, my job. And it

wasn't a problem, I loved it.

So I was lying there, and the phone rang. It was my friend Jimmy, and he said, "Mike, Frannie was in a car accident. Car flipped five times on 1-95."

No. She can't even walk. She's on so much morphine, there's no way. And, yet, I believed it, because I knew her. We were reformed drug addicts, recovering people. So even though she was suffering with AIDS, the morphine helped her feel better, and she probably just thought, ***Hey, I can drive.***

I knew she was dead, so I laid back, and I was just like, ***Wow.*** Because, quite honestly, my life -- the drugs and the tragedy and people dying that I loved, and most of all, my wife being so sick after being off drugs for so long -- it just seemed really unfair.

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All I knew about God was the one that I was told about as a kid, you know, ***God's watching. He knows.*** So I figured that the god who's doing this to me and my wife, I'm not gonna pray to ***him,*** you know? What am I gonna say? ***Can you help me?*** No. I'm gonna say, ***What are you doing? Get off the fence. Make a move. Kill us or help us.*** **Do** ***something.***

That wasn't really working for me, so I went to this Buddhist place, because I saw an ad in the paper. I thought, ***I'm gonna go see.*** So I walk in, and they told me to take my shoes off. They were very sweet and kind, and they had a lot of compassion. This woman said, "Would you like to see the lama?"

I'm thinking it's an animal they've got somewhere, like a sheep type of thing, so I said, "What's a llama?" She said, "No, it's a Tibetan priest."

When she said the word "priest," I immediately thought of, you know, a scary Catholic priest . . . So I walk in there to meet this guy. He's a little man, and he's just sitting there, mumbling a chant, and I'm like, ***What's he doing?*** And she says: "He just prays

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and meditates. He's been doing that since he escaped Tibet with his family. He does this for twenty-some-odd hours a day. Come sit near him."

I don't know about anyone else, but as a kid if I was in church kneeling and my knees didn't hurt, I was in trouble. Your knees had to hurt in order to be really praying right. So I actually got on my knees, like a good Catholic, and she goes, "No, relax, relax."

I put my hands out, and he took my hands. And when he touched me, I felt so relaxed. I wasn't scared. All the pain went away. I went there every day for a few weeks, meditating and praying.

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Now I'm in the hospital, waiting for my friend to call me back with more news about my wife's accident. But I've got these Tibetan beads, and I'm thinking of this man, and I'm okay. He blessed these beads for me.

And the phone rings again. But it's not my friend, it's my mother, and she says, "Daddy has a brain tumor." Yeah, this was a bad day. This news just froze me. I took the beads, and I threw them. I was like, ***You know what? I've been a Christian, Catholic, angry person for twenty-seven years, and now I'm a Buddhist for like three weeks. I don't want that little bit of peace, man. It just makes the rest of life seem so much *worse*.***

The phone rings again, so now I'm like, ***Okay, they are going to tell me my wife's dead.*** And it ***was*** Jimmy, but he said, "Mike, Frannie's okay. Relax."

She had actually been taken to the same hospital I was in, so I had to go visit her down in the emergency room. ***Will you give me a break here? My dad has a brain tumor, and I'm going to visit my dying wife down in the ER. She didn't die from flipping over the car, but she's gonna die soon anyway. I'm gonna go visit her now, and I've got pneumonia.***

A couple of weeks went by, and she ended up in hospice. Young people don't like to die, you know? Not that old people do, but some old people can say, ***I had a good life.***

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She didn't feel that way. She was ***pissed.*** She didn't wanna die. She was thrown out of hospice for not dying. This happened three times. But finally, this time, she died. I froze. I knew my father was now going to die, too, and I loved my father. We were so close.

Nine months after my wife died, I was out at a movie. I came home, and there was a voice mail from my brother, "Mike, pick up the phone. Mike, pick up the phone." Every time I heard him say "Pick up the phone," I felt a little more fear of what he was going to say. Finally he said, "Daddy's gone."

I'll never forget where I was. I was standing in front of my laundry machines, listening. And I felt my heart get ripped outta me. And that was it. The flame that I had as a kid -- all of it -- was gone, because now everyone had died.

I made arrangements to fly home the next day, and when I got on the plane, I decided that I was going to end my life. I was done. I wasn't telling anyone. It wasn't a threat, it was a decision that I'd had enough of this. There was nothing else to live for. I couldn't wait until the funeral was over, because that was when I was going to do it. I wasn't going to jump off a building or jump in front of a car. People haven't heard of overdosing on drugs?

But all my life God or the universe, or whoever's running this thing, would always go, ***Yeah, it's really awful now. You're almost out of hope. But here's a little something nice to keep you going.***

So . . . I went to the back of the plane to go to the bathroom. And the lama, the monk that I had met, is sitting in the back row. He sees me, and he put his hands out like he did before. What he was doing is called ***tonglen*** *. You have to have amazing karma, they say, to have a lama actually want to do ***tonglen*** with you. What they are doing is saying, ***Give me all your pain, and I'm gonna give you all my joy.***

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The reason he sat for thirty years in meditation was to open his heart so much that it gets as big as the ocean, so that if you pour some of your pain into it, it absorbs it. That's what his whole life was about. And it worked for me . . . I got home and I've got these Tibetan beads, and I'm thinking of this man, and I'm okay . . . He blessed these beads for me.

***Tonglen:** an ancient Buddhist practice to awaken compassion. With each in-breath, we take in others' pain. With each out-breath, we send them relief.*

SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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